am decidedly of the opinion that a Queen's officer, be he ever so talented, is totally unfit to command the Company's Army.'

To everyone's relief, the rains had stopped by the time the now grandly named Army of the Indus began to assemble on the plains of Ferozepur in early November. To try and cheer up the camp, Ranjit Singh sent 600 of his gardeners to arrange impromptu gardens of potted roses around the officer's tents. But a more serious obstacle to the war now confronted the gathering armies. To Auckland's embarrassment, in the midst of all the preparations for the invasion, news came that the Persians, alarmed by the British naval occupation of the island of Kharg, had unexpectedly abandoned the siege of Herat and withdrawn to Mashhad. Soon afterwards came confirmation that Count Nesselrode in St Petersburg had also given way, this time to diplomatic pressure from the Foreign Secretary, Lord Palmerston, in London. Count Simonitch, the author of the entire Russian diplomatic campaign to outflank the British in Persia and Afghanistan, was to be sacrificed – removed from his job as ambassador to the Persian court on the grounds that he had exceeded his instructions.[p] Vitkevitch was also to be recalled to St Petersburg from Kandahar, where he had been busy reinforcing the Russian–Barakzai alliance by promising Dost Mohammad's half-brothers Russian military support in the event of a British invasion.

Both of Auckland's original *casus belli* were now removed: Russia and Persia were publicly backing down. If there had ever been any real threat to British India it was now over. This would have been an ideal moment to reopen negotiations with Dost Mohammad and achieve all the aims of the war without a shot being fired. There was, after all, still a major famine in north India which had left tens and quite possibly hundreds of thousands starving to death – there are no official statistics – and whose horrors had been greatly exacerbated by the British encouragement of poppy growing over food crops. There was also the increasing likelihood that Auckland would choose to fight a second illegal war of aggression on a different front – this time with China – in order to protect the Company's profitable trade in the opium grown from those very poppy fields which had once produced such rich harvests of grain. Then there were all the uncertainties of Shuja's reception in Afghanistan, and the unanswered question as to whether it would be possible to maintain him on his throne once re-established. But, astonishingly, no one at Ferozepur seemed to have given a moment's thought to the option of reopening negotiations.